



FOLK SAINTS AND THE RISE IN POPULARITY OF SANTA MUERTE



Scan to review worksheet

Expemo code:

1HFX-51LD-003



1

Warm up

In pairs, discuss the following questions.

1. Do you know what a saint is? Can you name any saints?
2. What type of person can become a saint?
3. Have you heard about any modern saints?
4. Why are saints more popular in some countries than in others?





2

Focus on keywords

Match the underlined words to the definitions below.

1. Saint Valentine is well-known for being connected to love and romance.
 2. The local charities provided food and clothes for the poor.
 3. After the singer passed away last year, their songs became even more popular.
 4. There had been an increase in violent crime over the last year.
 5. My son didn't like being in his crib; he was always trying to climb over the side.
 6. Greyhounds are very athletic, but they are also very gentle.
- a. (n) people who do not have a lot of money
 - b. (n) a small bed with high sides for a baby
 - c. (adj.) using physical force to hurt or damage somebody/ something
 - d. (n) a large thin dog that can run very fast
 - e. (n) a person that the Christian church considers to be very holy
 - f. (phr. v) dying

3

Listen for predictions

Part A: Look at the table below, and with your partner try to predict how the information above the table is related to three different folk saints. Compare with your partner, then listen and check your predictions.

Argentina's cowboy saint

Could perform amputations

Dressed in red has a mustache.

He was just a dog

Was killed by a knight

Born in 1898

Died in 1938

Fought in Argentina in the 19th century

Local residents amazed by him

	Your Prediction	Correct Answer
Gauchito Gil		1
		2
		3
Niño Fidencio		4
		5
		6
Saint Guinefort		7
		8
		9



Part B: Read the sentences from the script and think about which words from the vocabulary section could go in the gaps, only four are needed. Afterwards listen to the audio and check your predictions.

1. ... In a _____ act the knight killed Guinefort ...
2. ... and he was known to steal from the rich and give to the _____ ...
3. ... bravery in saving the baby, and felt the loyal _____ deserved to be made into a saint
...
4. ... you are probably more than aware of the term patron _____ ...

4**Listen for details**

Listen one more time and try to answer the following questions.

1. What did Gauchito Gil do after he was in the army?
2. What can you see all over Argentina?
3. When would Niño find himself in front of people?
4. What did Fidencio use to perform surgery?
5. In which part of France would you find Saint Guinefort?
6. What did the knight and his wife leave Guinefort to do?

5**Discussion**

Look at the questions and discuss with your partner.

1. Which of the folk saints has the most interesting story? Why?
2. Do you think it was okay for Gauchito Gil to steal from the rich and give to the poor? Why / why not?
3. Do you believe that Niño Fidencio could perform surgery with a piece of a broken glass? Why / why not?
4. Do you think it is possible for a dog to be a saint? Do you think any other animals could be saints?



6

Focus on vocabulary

Part A: Match the following vocabulary to the definitions.

- | | |
|--------------------------|---|
| 1. <u>rejected</u> (v) | a. said something is true |
| 2. <u>ceremonies</u> (n) | b. refused to accept or consider something |
| 3. <u>worship</u> (v) | c. speak to god, usually to give thanks or ask for help |
| 4. <u>pavement</u> (n) | d. public or religious events that include traditional actions |
| 5. <u>pray</u> (v) | e. places where people go to worship because they are connected to a particular person or event |
| 6. <u>claimed</u> (v) | f. show respect for a religious figure through prayer, singing, etc. |
| 7. <u>factors</u> (n) | g. a number of things that cause or influence something else |
| 8. <u>shrines</u> (n) | h. a flat part at the side of the road for people to walk on |

Part B: Put the vocabulary from Part A into the correct gaps in the following sentences.

ceremonies claimed factors pavement prayed rejected shrines worship

1. I got in trouble for riding my bike on the _____.
2. On New Year's Day, many people in Japan visit _____.
3. The university _____ my application, and now I don't know what I will do.
4. Every night he _____ and asked God to help him succeed.
5. One of the main _____ for the poor financial performance, is the lack of money.
6. Traditional wedding _____ have started to become more popular with the younger generation.
7. Jessica _____ that she was the fastest kid in her class.
8. The Ancient Egyptians had festivals to _____ their gods.



7

Skimming for general understanding

Skim the article. Read the following paragraph titles and match them to the correct paragraph. Two are not needed. Listen to the article to check your answers.



The Rise in Popularity of Santa Muerte

The Story of Mexico's "Bony Lady"

A. _____

In Mexico, the rise in fame of Santa Muerte (the Saint of Death) began in the nineties and continues today. This dark folk saint has suddenly been changed into a figure of hope for the most forgotten groups within the country. The fact that she has been rejected by both the Church and the Mexican government hasn't stopped her from being very popular.

B. _____

Santa Muerte first appeared in a Spanish report from 1797, which recorded idols that were well-loved by the locals; however, at that time, any ceremonies involving Santa Muerte were secret, and often involved helping sick people. It was not until the 1940s when this folk saint became important to more people. She seemed to connect with the groups of people who had been kicked out by the church and the state.

C. _____

In 2001, an important event happened that meant followers of the Bony Lady no longer had to worship in private. A woman known as Doña Queta set up a place for Santa Muerte outside her house. The large statue was placed on the pavement where people walking by could pray or leave gifts. Before this event, Santa Muerte's followers had to worship privately, but now, they were free to do what they wanted.

D. _____

People are attracted to Santa Muerte for a couple of reasons. Firstly, she is seen as being fair, which means criminals are treated fairly. This would explain her huge popularity in some of Mexico City's most dangerous neighborhoods. Secondly, there has been a loss of faith within the country as people feel that Catholic saints have been unable to help them.

E. _____

As the popularity of Santa Muerte has continued to grow so has the opposition. Some observers are worried by the connection between the folk saint and the country's drug dealers. It has been claimed that shrines to Santa Muerte have been found in the homes of gang members.

F. _____

Despite the negative voices, this special religious movement continues to grow, and not just in Mexico. In the USA, her impact continues to grow. Her influence over many countries has improved because she was on TV shows such as *Breaking Bad* and *Dexter*, and also because of the fact that you can buy Santa Muerte-inspired objects on websites like Amazon. While it is clear that a number of factors have helped her rise, it seems as of now there is no stopping the Bony Lady.

Sources: *Magnum Photos, The Culture Trip, BBC, Vice, JSTOR Daily, EFE, Mexico News Daily, The Manitoban, NBC News*



1. Two-hundred-year-old story
2. A saint for the king
3. Spread across South America
4. Drug connections
5. Reasons for popularity
6. The dark saint of hope
7. No more private worship
8. Growing in America

8 Reading comprehension

Read the following statements and decide if they are True (T) or False (F).

1. Santa Muerte was first written about in a Mexican report from the 18th century. _____
2. Doña Queta put up a little statue of Santa Muerte in her neighborhood. _____
3. In some of Mexico City's riskiest areas Santa Muerte is well-liked by a lot of people. _____
4. People believe that Catholic saints have given them a better life. _____
5. There has been no evidence of Santa Muerte worship in the houses owned by gang members. _____
6. In the USA Santa Muerte's influence hasn't increased. _____
7. You can buy Santa Muerte's objects in real shops but not online. _____

9 Discussion

Look at the questions and discuss with your partner.

1. What did you think of the article? Why do you think Santa Muerte is so popular?
2. Do you think that Doña Queta did a good thing? Why / why not?
3. Is the link between Santa Muerte and Mexico's drug dealers a realistic one? Why / why not?
4. Why do you think she was featured shown on TV shows?
5. Can you imagine Santa Muerte becoming more popular in other countries around the world?



10

Vocabulary for conversation

Look at the examples of natural language from the listening and the article and try to guess the meaning of each one. To help you remember the expressions, have a discussion with your partner and use them to talk about your life.

- ... of a broken bottle and also had the ability to cure people from miles away ...
- ... In Mexico, the rise in fame of Santa Muerte (the Saint of Death) began in the nineties ...
- ... Her attraction seemed to connect with the groups of society who had been kicked out by the church and the state ...

Let's chat.

1. Have you ever seen an interesting animal from miles away? What was it?
2. Can you think of any people in your country who had a quick rise in fame? What did they become famous for?
3. Why would some parents choose to kick their children out of the family home?



Transcripts

3. Listen for predictions

Narrator: The Rise in Popularity of Santa Muerte

Narrator: The Story of Mexico's "Bony Lady"

Narrator: The Dark Saint of Hope

Narrator: In Mexico, the rise in fame of Santa Muerte (the Saint of Death) began in the nineties and continues today. This dark folk saint has suddenly been changed into a figure of hope for the most forgotten groups within the country. The fact that she has been rejected by both the Church and the Mexican government hasn't stopped her from being very popular.

Narrator: Two-hundred-year-old Story

Narrator: Santa Muerte first appeared in a Spanish report from 1797 which recorded idols that were well-loved by the locals, however at that time any ceremonies involving Santa Muerte were secret, and often involved helping sick people. It was not until the 1940s when this folk saint started to be important to more people. She seemed to connect with the groups of people who had been kicked out by the church and the state.

Narrator: No More Private Worship

Narrator: In 2001, an important event happened that meant followers of the Bony Lady no longer had to worship in private. A woman known as Doña Queta set up a place for Santa Muerte outside her house. The large statue was placed on the pavement where people walking by could pray or leave gifts. Before this event, Santa Muerte's followers had to worship privately but now, they were free to do what they wanted.

Narrator: Reasons for Popularity

Narrator: People are attracted to Santa Muerte for a couple of reasons. Firstly, she is seen as being fair which means criminals are treated fairly. This would explain her huge popularity in some of Mexico City's most dangerous neighborhoods. Secondly, there has been a loss of faith within the country as people feel that Catholic saints have been unable to help them.

Narrator: Drug Connections

Narrator: As the popularity of Santa Muerte has continued to grow so has the opposition. Some observers are worried by the connection between the folk saint and the country's drug dealers. It has been claimed that shrines to Santa Muerte have been found in the homes of gang members.

Narrator: Growing in America



Narrator: Despite the negative voices this special religious movement continues to grow, and not just in Mexico. In the USA her impact continues to grow. Her influence over many countries has been improved because she was on TV shows such as *Breaking Bad* and *Dexter*, and also the fact that you can buy Santa Muerte inspired objects on websites like Amazon. While it is clear that a number of factors have helped her rise, it seems as of now there is no stopping the Bony Lady.



Key

1. Warm up

5 mins.

This gives the teacher an opportunity to set the context and allows the students time to share their previous knowledge and their opinions in relation to saints. Monitor and provide on-the-spot feedback when appropriate.

2. Focus on keywords

5 mins.

Make sure students can correctly pronounce the target vocabulary. Ask them to complete the task by themselves first, and then compare answers with a partner.

1. → e. 2. → a. 3. → f. 4. → c. 5. → b. 6. → d.

3. Listen for predictions

Part A

5 min.

Put the students in pairs and ask them to fill in the prediction column, then listen to the audio check their answer (writing the corrected answer in the column provided) Students compare their answers with their partner.

1. Argentina's cowboy saint
2. Fought in Argentina in the 19th century
3. Dressed in red has a mustache.
4. Born in 1898
5. Could perform amputations
6. Died in 1938
7. He was just a dog
8. Was killed by a knight
9. Local residents amazed by him

Part B

5 mins.

Ask students to read the sentences from the transcript and discuss with their partner where they think each word from the vocabulary section goes. Play the audio and ask the students to check their predictions.

1. violent 2. poor 3. greyhound 4. saint

Sources for audio:

en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Folk_saint

wander-argentina.com/argentinas-gaicho-saint/

buenosairesstreetart.com/2024/01/gauchito-gil-murals-of-the-outlaw-and-folk-hero-in-argentina/

www.taosnews.com/opinion/columns/the-folk-saint-el-compa-ero-ni-o-fidencio/article_36e042b1-8831-5a42-8b8d-1155e4236f76.html



mexicocityhelicopter.com.mx/nino-fidencio-el-curandero-que-le-quito-la-lepra-a-un-presidente-de-mexico/
en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ni%C3%B1o_Fidencio
stguinefort.com/
en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Saint_Guinefort

4. Listen for details

5 mins.

Tell students that they are going to listen again, ask them to answer the questions and then compare their answers with their partner.

1. "...but he is thought to have become a criminal after his time in the army..."
2. "...Murals of this Argentine Robin Hood can now be seen all over Argentina..."
3. "... it would take until 1928 before Niño Fidencio would be in front of the public..."
4. "...surgery using a piece of a broken bottle ..."
5. "...as we travel to Lyon in France in the 13th century..."
6. "...left Guinefort behind to look after their baby..."

5. Discussion

5 mins.

Students discuss talking points from the audio and share their opinions about each folk saint.

6. Focus on vocabulary

Part A

5 mins.

Ensure students can correctly pronounce the target vocabulary. Ask them to complete the task by themselves firstly, and then compare answers with a partner.

1. → b. 2. → d. 3. → f. 4. → h. 5. → c. 6. → a. 7. → g. 8. → e.

Part B

5 mins.

Ask students to identify which parts of speech could fill the gaps before completing the exercise. Circulate and help as needed.

- | | | | |
|-------------|---------------|-------------|------------|
| 1. pavement | 2. shrines | 3. rejected | 4. prayed |
| 5. factors | 6. ceremonies | 7. claimed | 8. worship |

7. Skimming for general understanding

5 mins.

You may want to set a time limit and highlight the differences between skimming and scanning at this point. Play the audio for students to check their answers.

Not needed: 2. *A saint for the king*, 3. *Spread across South America*

A. 6. The Dark Saint of Hope



- B. 1. Two-hundred-year-old Story
- C. 7. No More Private Worship
- D. 5. Reasons for Popularity
- E. 4. Drug Connections
- F. 8. Growing in America

8. Reading comprehension

5 mins.

Ask students to read in more detail and complete the exercise. Ask them to underline where they find the answer and allow them to compare their answers in pairs.

- 1. False. ["...Santa Muerte first appeared in a Spanish report from 1797 ..."]
- 2. False. ["...The large statue was placed on the pavement ..."]
- 3. True. ["...her huge popularity in some of Mexico City's most dangerous neighborhoods..."]
- 4. False. ["...people feel that Catholic saints have been unable to help them..."]
- 5. False. ["...It has been claimed that shrines to Santa Muerte have been found in the homes of gang members..."]
- 6. False. ["...In the USA her impact continues to grow ..."]
- 7. False. ["...Santa Muerte inspired objects on websites like Amazon..."]

9. Discussion

5 mins.

Students discuss talking points from the article and share their opinions with each other about Santa Muerte and her influence.

10. Vocabulary for conversation

5 mins.

Ask students to look through the sentences together and try to guess the meaning, monitor to support and then allow them to personalize the vocabulary with a quick discussion.

from miles away - from a long distance

rise in fame - someone is becoming more well-known and popular, often rapidly

kicked out - forced to leave a place